Sure enough, Rahul strode in a little while later in his usual kurta–pyjama attire. Rolling up his sleeves, stroking his beard, he looked every inch the angry young man. ‘My opinion about the ordinance is that it is complete nonsense. It should be torn up and thrown away.’ Before the stunned journalists could seek a response, Rahul had walked away. It was a brief item number yet again—only here he was playing anti-establishment hero. Maken, who earlier had defended the ordinance, was clearly embarrassed but tried to put up a brave face. ‘Now that the Congress vice president has made it clear, the line is very clear. The Congress party is supreme.’

Later, I asked Maken if the entire exercise had been choreographed in advance to project Rahul as an anti-corruption crusader. ‘No, no, I had no idea that Rahul would make the statement. I was also caught unawares and was told about it just fifteen minutes before he made an appearance,’ he claimed. But just a day earlier, one of Rahul’s groupies, South Mumbai MP Milind Deora, had tweeted, ‘Legalities aside, allowing convicted MPs/MLAs to retain seats in the midst of an appeal can endanger already eroding public faith in democracy.’ Clearly, Team Rahul wanted to send out a message distancing themselves from the government decision.

The prime minister had been humiliated. Appearing on a TV programme that night, the prime minister’s former media adviser Dr Sanjaya Baru told me, ‘Enough is enough, Dr Singh should resign!’ Sonia Gandhi reportedly rang up the prime minister and made suitably apologetic noises on Rahul’s behalf. Rahul himself is believed to have admitted to Dr Singh that he should have framed his opposition to the ordinance in less combative terms. The prime minister wanted to step down but chose to keep the peace, yet again.

The sudden eruption in public reflected poorly on Rahul and the Congress party. His behaviour seemed brattish and disrespectful, hardly a sign of political maturity. It appears that his aides had convinced him at last that he needed to establish an independent identity ahead of the 2014 elections. He had to rid himself of the baggage of being part of the UPA-II’s decision-making process. If, as a result, the prime minister and even Sonia Gandhi were left a trifle red-faced, then that was a small price to pay. What